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Website <https://u3aepsom.nz/>.

MEETING PLACE

Royal Oak Bowls, 146 Selwyn St, Onehunga
10am on the 2ND Thursday of most months

NEWSLETTER

September 2026

**Next meeting
10-12noon
Thursday 10 September 2026**

It's September. The weather will improve, it will get warmer and there's a feel of Spring in the air. It's always a pleasure to see colour returning to the world. September seems to bring that quiet sense of renewal - lighter mornings, friendlier temperatures, and the unmistakable feeling that it's time to get moving again. It's the perfect season for curiosity, and fortunately, curiosity is something our u3a group has in abundance.

Over the coming weeks, I'd encourage everyone to make the most of the improving weather and get out to visit places—old favourites, new discoveries, or simply corners of Auckland you've never quite got around to exploring. A short wander through a garden, a museum you haven't visited in years, a local heritage site, or even a new café can be a small adventure. Spring rewards even modest outings with blossoms, birdsong, and that gentle lift in the spirit that comes from being out and about.

Our groups and activities continue to offer plenty of chances to learn, share, and connect, but September is also a wonderful time to add a little personal exploration to the mix. Whether you go with friends, family, or simply enjoy a quiet solo ramble, the season is on your side.

So here's to spring—its brightness, its promise, and its invitation to step outside and enjoy what's around us. Let's make the most of it.

Ian Jost

EPSOM U3A EXECUTIVE

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Kaye Buchanan - 021 299 0709

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Charmaine Strang – 027 4177 556

Interest Group Co-ordinators

Joslyn Squire – 021 168 0680

Bill Hagan – 021 611 247

Guest Speaker Organiser:

Ian Jost – 027 488 7037

Legal Advisor

Mike Matson – 022 630 7968

Newsletter

Jeanette Grant – 638 8566

Greeters:

Don Buchanan 0275 928 131

Helen Dallaston - 022-2647786

INTEREST GROUP CONVENERS

Applied Sciences

Peter Parsons - 021 521446

Attending Performing Arts

Shirin Caldwell – 630 1662

Architecture

Brian Murray – 021 026 68396

Art Appreciation

Kaye Buchanan – 021 299 0709

Art History

Emily Flynn – 021 0902 5094

Big History

Emily Flynn – 021 0902 5094

Book Chat

Helen Holdem - 021 260 3510

Chess Group

John Locke - 021-187 8061

Comparative Religions

Duncan MacDonald - 021-316 661

John Locke - 021-187 8061

Current Affairs

Shirley McConville – 622 3542

Fabric & Fibre Crafts

Charmaine Strang – 027-4177 556

Famous & Infamous Group

Shirley McConville – 622 3542

Foodies

Graham Gunn – 027 445 0929.

Garden Appreciation

Betty Townley - 021-080 39023

Introduction to Family History

Bryn Smith – 027 280 5235

Latin

Phyllis Downes – 630 5867

Lunch Bunch

Shirley McConville – 622 3542.

Music Appreciation

Carleen Edwards – 624 6298

History & Social Change

Helen Holdem – 021 260 3510

NZ History

Kaye Buchanan - 021 299 0709

Philosophy

Jocelyn Hewin - 634-1552

Scrabble

Joslyn Squire – 021 168 0680

Stories of the Past

Jeanette Grant – 638 8566

Te Reo Maori

Jenny Whatman – 027 353 2487

Travel

Diana Hart- 021 284 4402

AUGUST SPEAKER'S REPORT

Title: A 15th Century History: How a Unique Surgery Changed the Course of History

Once again, Ian Jost shared his love of mediaeval history, by giving an engaging talk about an incident in 1403 that involved a unique piece of surgery. Sixteen-year-old Prince Henry, son of Henry IV, was influenced by this event that would shape the next three hundred years of English history.

Henry IV had taken the throne by force after murdering Richard II, causing civil unrest and rebellion. As he had usurped the throne, others believed they had equal rights to do the same. Sir Henry Percy (Harry Hotspur) was guardian to Edmund Mortimer, great-great-grandson of Edward III, who he believed had a legitimate right to the throne. Percy's ulterior motive was to gain power himself, as an advisor to the eleven-year-old young man. This later led to the Battle of Shrewsbury, in which Edward, who was trained to be a tough young warrior, gathered 10,000 supporters, and fought against the royalists with 14,000 men.

It was a hot, humid summer and with the men wearing heavy 40kg armour, and the death toll of 3-5000 was high. During the battle, 16 year-old Prince Henry raised his visor to see better and breathe more freely, but took an unbarbed arrow, full in the face, the arrow piercing close to the eye, brain and spinal cord. His bodyguards retrieved him from the battlefield and took him to Kennelworth Castle. Several doctors attended the injured prince to no avail, and though the wooden shaft of the arrow was removed, the metal point stayed lodged in the skull. They all feared Henry, the heir to the throne, would die of septicaemia.

Dr John Bradmore, a respected pious surgeon, who was also a metal worker, was then consulted. This interesting man had been accused in 1386 of counterfeiting coins, though his accusers withdrew their complaint, saving him from death for committing treason. He was known for his charitable works with the Westminster Abbey Infirmary, and was a married property owner with two children. He was a churchwarden at Saint Botolph's Aldersgate, assisting the poor and working with Dr John Middleton.

John Bradmore wrote up detailed case notes of Prince Henry's injuries and treatment, which is how we know today what occurred. Bradmore used his metalworking skills to invent special surgical tongs with a screw attachment, that could be used to draw out the arrowhead. He first used a stick covered in linen impregnated with rose and honey to dilate the wound, allowing the tongs to expand then grip the arrowhead when screwed, thus slowly drawing it out,.

To cleanse the wound, Bradmore squirted white wine in the wound, the alcohol providing antiseptic. After that, for the next twenty days, he made potions and ointments which were applied morning and evening. Some of the substances in these ointments were breadcrumbs, barley flour, and honey, boiled and strained. then mixed with turpentine. He also made a brown ointment using camphor oil, olive oil, suet and meadowsweet, which contains salicylate, a substance found in our modern aspirin. A nerve ointment, to minimise pain, was made using suet, lard, rue, sage, camomile, rosemary, turpentine, cloves, nutmeg and cinnamon. Miraculously young Prince Henry lived and was cured in three weeks, though it is believed that he was left with a drooping scarred eyelid. He then went on to be crowned King Henry V in 1413.

The former wild child, who had loved to drink in taverns with the locals, was now changed, becoming convinced that his survival had been orchestrated by God, giving him divine approval and authority. He became a monk-warrior. John Bradmore was made surgeon to the King, paid 40 shillings (about 4000 pounds today) and received another payment of 40 shillings for robes, as well as a lifetime annuity. He was also made Searcher of the Port of London (Honorary) with a ten-pound salary and was appointed Master of the Fraternity of the Trinity, a guild at Saint Botolphs.

On his death. Henry V was buried in Westminster Abbey, but when Bradmore died, he was buried in Saint Botolphs' churchyard, the area being totally destroyed in the Great Fire of London in 1666.

By Joslyn Squire

MAIN SPEAKER	Our September speaker is Janine Nillesen. Janine is a park ranger at Ambury Farm, a position she has held for the last twenty-five years. She has served as the co-chair (and main driving force) of the Friends of the Farm, a group that supports zero-waste initiatives, practical working bees and neighbourhood events. Janine infuses the park with her irrepressible personality and sense of the joy of life. She teaches kids how to milk cows and shear sheep, she manages the Mangere foreshore to ensure migratory birds can feed, and builds powerful bonds with the local community. The NZ Herald has described her as “unstoppable” and “a force to be reckoned with”. Janine will talk to us about Ambury Park and the foreshore, her work and life there, her passion for zero-waste, and Friends of the Farm.
INTEREST GROUPS	<i>Gardening Appreciation Group needs a new Convenor for next year.</i> Betty Townley, our current Convenor for the Gardening Appreciation group is stepping down at the end of the year. The current group meets on Friday Week 4 from 1:30-3:30pm. They have visited some of Auckland’s fabulous home gardens and Public gardens. They have speakers and watch You Tube videos relating to the group’s interest. If you enjoy meeting with enthusiastic gardeners you might like to be the Convenor, and there is the possibility that the current venue can continue to be available when needed during the year. Please contact Bill Hagan or Betty Townley if you are interested.
SOME INTERESTING FACTS ABOUT U3A	Membership numbers in the branches average 156 with the highest 388 and the lowest 45. The total membership for the u3a Auckland Network is now 4373, an increase of 7% over last year. The membership has been steadily increasing from 3254 when we started keeping records in 2014 to 4373 now. This steady increase proves our popularity among the third age members of our community. Hall rentals average \$175.00 with the highest \$546.00 and the lowest \$27.50. One surprising statistic is that the very u3a that had one of the lowest hall costs in 2015 now has the highest of all u3as. The average back then was \$88.00. Membership subs – average \$37.00 with the highest \$55.00 and the lowest \$20.00. Average in 2015 \$27.00.
2026 MEETING DATES Thursdays, 10am	10 September 8 October 12 November AGM NB Always wear your name badge and be seated ready at 10am

TRANSPARENT SOLAR POWER CELLS

One of the hindrances of solar power adoption, especially in cities, is where to install the chunky panels. Roofs? Skyscraper walls? Scarce open spaces? Researchers say they have solved this with solar cells so thin they can be installed on windows! The team claims to have developed ultrathin, semi-transparent perovskite solar cells that are roughly 10,000 times thinner than a strand of human hair and about 50 times thinner than conventional perovskite solar cells, while still retaining some of the highest efficiencies yet reported for devices in this ultrathin category.

Their work, recently published in ACS Energy Letters, could eventually pave the way for electricity-generating windows, glass facades, smart glasses, vehicle sunroofs, and other surfaces that currently sit passively in the sunlight.

The idea of transparent solar cells is not entirely new. Researchers around the world have spent years trying to create photovoltaics that can blend into glass and urban infrastructure. The problem is that solar panels are fundamentally designed to absorb sunlight. The more light a solar cell captures, the less transparent it tends to become.

Existing commercial solar panels are also physically bulky systems consisting not just of photovoltaic materials but also of thick protective glass, encapsulation layers, metallic contacts, mounting hardware, and structural framing. Typical residential solar panels weigh around 18 to 23 kg (40 to 50 lb) each and generate roughly 350 to 450 W of power under ideal conditions.

A modern office tower can easily consume several gigawatt-hours of electricity annually. Now, imagine the sheer amount and weight of solar panels powering such a building independently. Where could they possibly be mounted? In this context, the roofs appear ridiculously small. An alternative would be vast open land, but many cities simply do not have it...

The real breakthrough of the technology may not simply be the thinness of the solar cells, but how the NTU team manufactured them. The researchers used an industrially compatible vacuum-based technique called thermal evaporation, in which materials are heated in a vacuum chamber until they vaporize and settle onto a surface as an ultrathin film. According to the team, this may be the first time ultrathin perovskite solar cells have been produced entirely using vacuum processing, an approach already widely used in semiconductor and display manufacturing.

The team, led by Associate Professor Annalisa Bruno from NTU's School of Physical and Mathematical Sciences and School of Materials Science and Engineering, developed the new devices using perovskites: a class of crystalline materials that have become one of the hottest areas in solar research over the last decade due to their potentially low manufacturing costs, high efficiencies, and ability to function under lower-light conditions.

Read more at <https://newatlas.com/energy/transparent-solar-cells-windows/>?

DNA PROVES WOMEN'S HIGH STATUS.

Genetic analysis of people buried in a 2000 year-old cemetery in Dorset, England have confirmed the belief that women had high status within Celtic societies across Europe and gives credence to the Roman written accounts which were often thought by Mediterranean audiences to be exaggerated.

The Durotriges tribe occupied the central southern English coast from around 100BC to 100AD and while human remains from this period are rare, the fact that this tribe did not cremate their dead but buried them in a chalk landscape, has aided their preservation.

Archaeologists have found that Durotringan women were more often buried with valuable items, suggesting high status.

Recently a team from Trinity College, Dublin, has analysed the genomes of 55 individuals to discover how they were related. Mitochondrial DNA has revealed that over two-thirds of these individuals were descended from a common female ancestor who had lived a few centuries earlier. This is clear evidence of a matrilineal society where the women inherit and stay put while the men are the ones to move to live with their wives.

To find out whether this was unique to the Durotriges, the team began trawling through data from an earlier large genetic survey of Iron Age Britain and Europe. They found other instances where cemeteries across Britain showed most individual were maternal descendants of a small set of female ancestors.

This adds evidence to the growing pile of evidence that before the Romans came, Iron Age women were relatively empowered. They would remain in their ancestral homes while men moved in from elsewhere and cultural practices would keep them embedded in their family support networks.

WHAT ACTUALLY HELPS WHEN YOU HAVE A COLD OR FLU?

For nasal congestion, short-term use of a decongestant nasal spray containing phenylephrine, oxymetazoline or xylometazoline can provide relief. This means using them for a maximum of three days.

Using them for longer can cause your symptoms to worsen or come back worse when you stop using them – this is called rebound congestion.

Saline nasal sprays or rinses also help to clear nasal congestion safely and effectively, by physically dislodging phlegm, without the risk of rebound congestion.

For other options, speak to your pharmacist. In some cases, a GP or pharmacist may recommend products that contain pseudoephedrine. You may need to show identification to the pharmacist, depending on the state or territory.

Paracetamol and ibuprofen can also help ease symptoms such as headache, body aches and fevers. Steam inhalation or warm showers may provide some temporary relief.

But there is no way to treat the cause, which is typically a virus.

The best thing you can do is rest, stay hydrated, and keep your germs to yourself. You should start feeling better in around seven to ten days and, if not, it's time to see your doctor.

Jack Janetzki, Lecturer in Pharmacy and Pharmacology, Adelaide University and Lauren Cortis, Senior Lecturer in Pharmacy Practice, Adelaide University

NAMING STORMS

The practice of using names to identify tropical cyclones goes back several centuries, with storms named after places, saints or things they hit before the formal start of naming in each basin. The present practice of naming hurricanes and typhoons began between 1887 and 1907 when Clement Wragge, a British meteorologist working in Queensland, started naming storms after Polynesian women and politicians he disliked. This system of naming fell into disuse for several years after Wragge retired, until it was revived in the latter part of World War II for the Western Pacific. The practice became popular among forecasters who found that it reduced confusion during map discussions. Using female names caught on with US meteorologists in the 1950s; weather reports included sexist clichés about 'temperamental' storms 'flirting' with coastlines. Male names were finally included by 1979.

The association with destruction tends to make some storm names unpopular baby names – which is what happened to Katrina after a Category 5 storm with that name devastated the US state of Louisiana in 2005. A very devastating storm may have its name retired, and some years there are enough storms to run through the 21 alphabetical names (Q, U, X, Y, and Z are not used). A name is retired or withdrawn if a consensus or majority of members agree that the tropical cyclone has acquired a special notoriety, such as causing a large number of deaths, significant impacts, or for other special reasons. The World Meteorological Organisation keeps a list of backup names prepared for that eventuality.

MOUNT ETNA IS UNIQUE

Europe's most active volcano, Mount Etna, has always been a geological puzzle. The Sicilian volcano has erupted several times a year, and glassy peaks of over 3,000 meters (10,000 feet) have fascinated scientists for decades. Though renowned, Etna has stubbornly defied categorization in the traditional volcano lifecycle.

Now, a group of researchers at the University of Lausanne (UNIL), in collaboration with their colleagues from Italy's Istituto Nazionale di Geofisica e Vulcanologia (INGV), is putting forth another wildly contested explanation. The work published in the *Journal of Geophysical Research – Solid Earth* indicates that Etna could have formed through a unique volcanic process previously only identified in small submerged volcanoes. If verified, Etna would become a geological one-off: a colossal stratovolcano nourished by a mechanism that bears no resemblance to any other large volcano on Earth...

The UNIL team proposes that Etna is fed by pre-existing pockets of magma stored in the upper mantle's Low Velocity Zone (LVZ), about 80 kilometers below the surface. These melts don't form just before eruptions, as in most volcanoes. Instead, they linger for long periods until tectonic forces squeeze them upward. *"As the tectonic plate bends near the subduction zone, fractures develop, allowing the magma to rise through the crust, much like liquid being squeezed from a sponge,"* the researchers explain.

Mount Etna, by contrast, is a large stratovolcano, whose activity began around 500,000 years ago and which now towers more than 3,000 meters above sea level." Petit-spot volcanoes were first identified off Japan in 2006. They are tiny compared to Etna, but they provide evidence for magma pockets near the lithosphere–asthenosphere boundary. Etna may be the first large volcano formed by this same process.

The team investigated rock samples from half a million years of eruptions to look into Etna's origins. The results showed that the geochemistry of magma in Etna, for the most part, has remained surprisingly consistent over time, even though tectonic shifts have occurred in the region...is fueled by stably residing mantle melts as opposed to transient magmas generated by subduction or hotspots.